

Rostas

Coordinator Guide

Knox Church Waitara

June 2026

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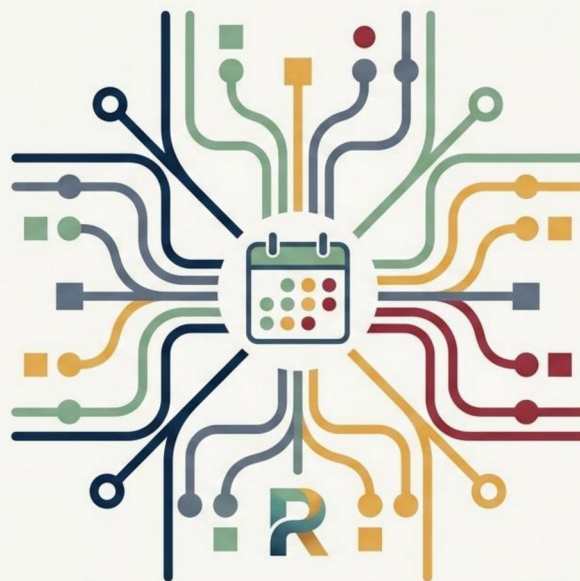
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Quick Start Guide — Orchestrating with Empathy

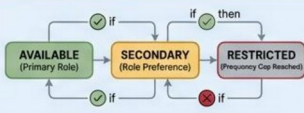
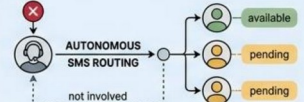
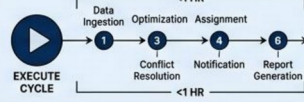
Orchestrating with Empathy

The Rostas Playbook for
Coordinators at Knox
Church Waitara
May 2026



NotebookLM

Transitioning from static scheduling to a dynamic engine

Legacy Manual Systems	The Rostas Engine
 Flat Availability: Volunteers are treated as a simple 'yes' or 'no'.	 Granular Logic: Utilizes three availability states, primary/secondary role preferences, and strict frequency caps.
 Coordinator Intervention: Cancellations require the coordinator to act as a middleman, sending emails and making phone calls to find replacements.	 Automated Autonomy: Cancellations trigger an autonomous SMS replacement chain that routes around the coordinator directly to available backups.
 Vulnerable to Burnout: Relies heavily on the same few volunteers, often leading to quiet resignations.	 Protected Energy: The engine enforces monthly limits and tracks historical scheduling to ensure fair rotation.
 High Administrative Load: A single roster cycle requires two to three hours of manual data entry and cross-referencing.	 Orchestrated Efficiency: A full cycle is reduced to under an hour through a six-step, single-button workflow.

NotebookLM

System access is purposefully distilled to protect data integrity

	Roster Coordinator	Overall Coordinator	Tech Support
Sync roster types	✓	✓	✓
View/Edit volunteer data	✓	✓	✓
Build/Edit rosters	✓	✓	✓
Manage Replacements	✓	✓	✓
Sync volunteers from Infoodle		✓	✓
Add new volunteers/roster types		✓	✓
Apps Script / Technical changes			✓

Note: Infoodle remains the ultimate source of truth. Name changes and new volunteer additions must be processed in Infoodle before syncing to Rostas.

NotebookLM

The roster follows a strict, sequential seven-step sequence



NotebookLM

Step 0 & 1 establish a synchronised foundation before processing availability

Step 0: Refresh the Seasons Calendar

0. Refresh calendar

Function: Recalculates all roster dates and overlays New Zealand public and school holidays.



Rule: This must be run after editing any season start or end dates, or at the exact beginning of a new roster cycle.

Step 1: Sync Volunteers from Infoodle

1. Sync volunteers from Infoodle

Function: Pulls fresh volunteer data and group memberships. (Runs automatically at 2:00 AM daily, but can be triggered manually).



Warning: Rostas strictly reads from Infoodle. If a volunteer is missing, they must be added to the Infoodle database first.

NotebookLM

Step 2 captures exact role preferences to optimize assignments

Volunteers are sent a personalised link to set their preferences for the season. This prevents the system from assigning a volunteer to a role they are unqualified for or uncomfortable performing.

The Three-Tier Preference System:

- 1. **Primary Roles:** The default, preferred tasks a volunteer enjoys.
- 2. **Backup Roles:** Tasks a volunteer is capable of, but prefers not to do regularly ("Happy to fill in").
- ✖ 3. **Excluded Roles:** Tasks the volunteer cannot perform. The engine will strictly ignore these candidates for these roles.

Coordinators can also manually set these preferences via the editable 'Preferred Roles' list in the Rostas desktop view for volunteers who do not use the web link.



NotebookLM

Frequency caps strictly protect volunteer energy and prevent burnout

Frequency settings control the maximum number of times per month a volunteer can be rostered for a specific roster type.

- The defaults are set to 4 for weekly rosters and 2 for fortnightly rosters.
- Coordinators can adjust this downward in the 'Volunteer Details' view for individuals needing a lighter load.
- Notes can be added to clarify specific arrangements (e.g., "4th Monday only").

Max Days Rostered

1 2 3 **4** Days Per Month



Insight

The Engine Rule: The automated system strictly enforces this monthly maximum. Once a cap is reached, the system will actively bypass the volunteer for the remainder of the month, even if they have explicitly marked themselves as "Available" for those dates.

NotebookLM

Step 3 gathers precise availability via a three-state selection process

Volunteers receive a personalised availability link. Everything defaults to "Available" — volunteers only need to interact with dates they cannot make.

✓
Available

?
Unsure

✗
Can't make it

The Automated Nudge Protocol:

1. Send: Availability emails are dispatched via the Run Commands dashboard.

2. Wait: The system waits the configured duration (default: 2 days).

3. Evaluate: A daily background process identifies non-responders.

4. Nudge: An SMS reminder with a direct link is sent automatically.

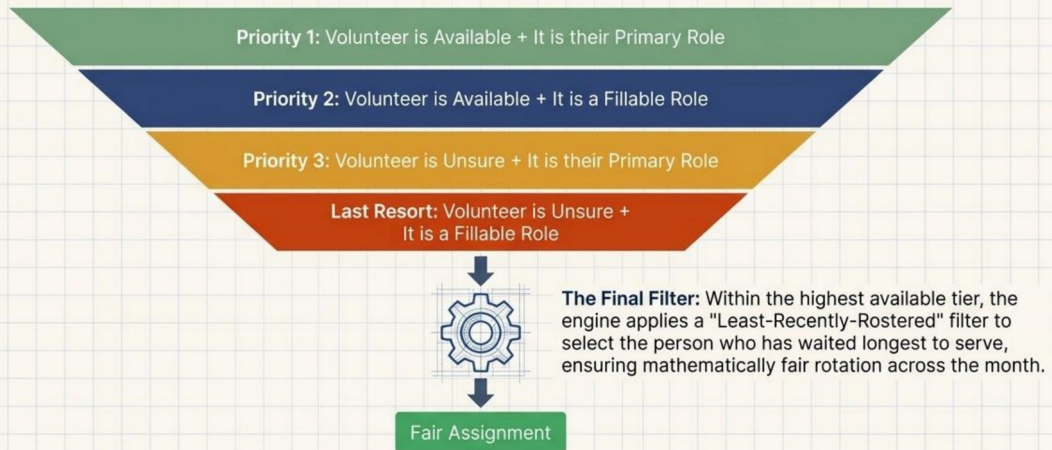


This fires exactly once per cycle to respect the volunteer's inbox. Opted-out volunteers are silently skipped.

NotebookLM

The Roster Engine logic synthesizes availability, preferences, and history

When Step 4 ("Build Roster") is triggered, the system does not fill slots blindly. It filters every volunteer through a strict four-tier priority matrix:



NotebookLM

Step 4 & 5 require auditing the output via the Traffic Light UI

Rostas builds the next 8 weeks of dates by default. Before proceeding, coordinators must inspect the Global Roster view.

Step 4 Audit: Global Roster Day view

Mon	Tue	Wed	Thu	Fri	Sat	Sun
1 Mon 18, 3AM-12PM	2 Mon 19, 1PM-4PM	3	4	5	6	7
18	19 Tue 19, 10AM-1PM	20	21 Thu 21, 10AM-1PM	12 Fri 22, 2PM-5PM	13	17
18	19 Tue 19, 1PM-4PM	20 Wed 20, 3PM-6PM	21	22 Fri 22, 2PM-5PM	23 Sat 23, 11AM-2PM	24 Sun 24, 3AM-12PM
25	26	27	28	29	30	1

The Status Indicators:

- ✓ Green (Filled): A solid assignment.
- ? Amber (Pending): An assignment where the volunteer marked themselves 'Unsure'.
- ✗ Red (Unfilled): The engine could not find an available volunteer. These require manual coordinator intervention to locate a substitute or adjust role requirements.

Step 5 Preview: Comms Dashboard



Step 5 (Preview Communications):

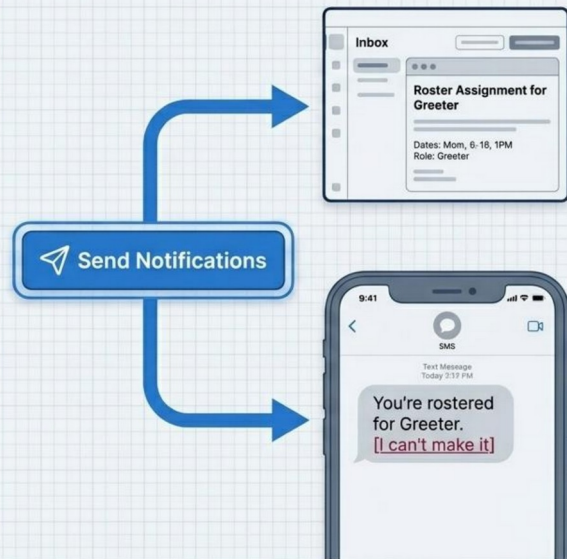
Utilize the Comms Dashboard to preview the exact wording, dates, and layouts of all pending emails and SMS notifications before dispatching them.

NotebookLM

Step 6 dispatches all confirmed assignments instantly

With a single tap on "Send Notifications" in the Run Commands view, Rostas dispatches assignments to every volunteer with a Filled or Pending status.

- The volunteer receives an email detailing their role and dates.
- A corresponding SMS is sent simultaneously.
- Pending volunteers receive explicit "Yes, I can make it" and "Can't make it" confirmation buttons to lock in their status.
- All communications include a "Can't make it" fail-safe link to handle unexpected changes.

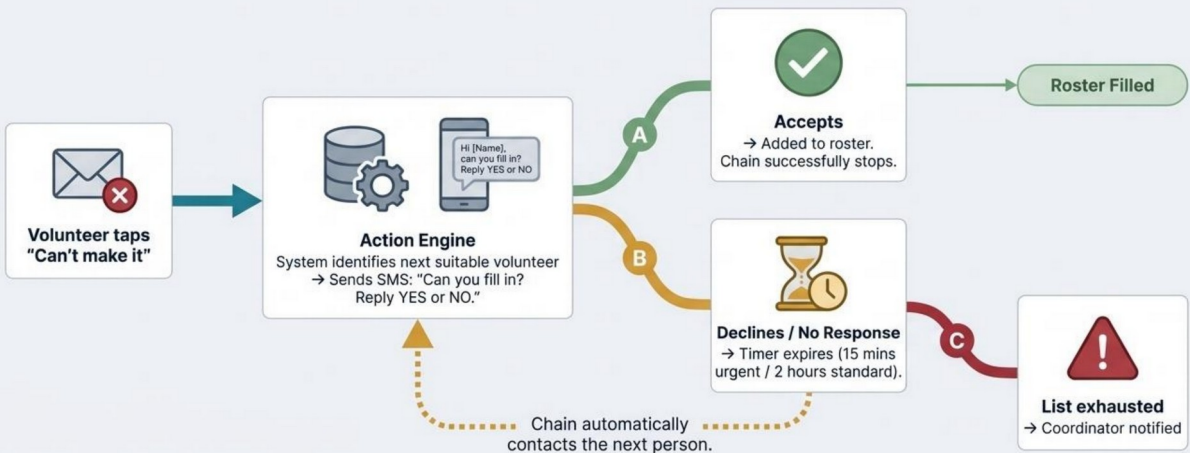


NotebookLM

The automated SMS chain executes stress-free replacements

When a volunteer taps 'Can't make it', the coordinator is removed from the friction of finding a replacement. The system takes over immediately.

 System Parameter:
SMS traffic pauses
automatically between
9:00 PM and 8:00 AM
NZ time to respect
volunteers' privacy.

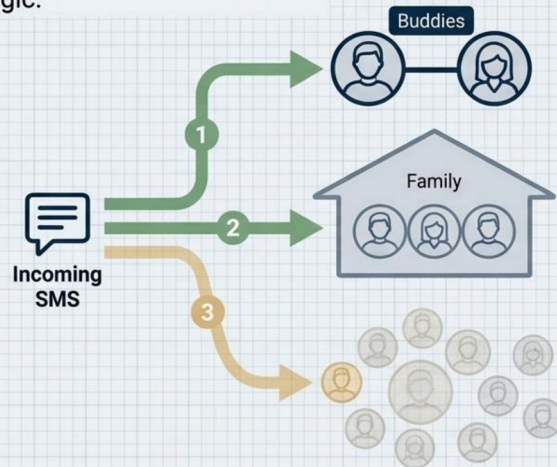


NotebookLM

Relational Rostering aligns households and preferred buddies

An advanced feature activated via the Quick Controls panel, Relational Rostering adds an empathetic secondary pass to the engine logic.

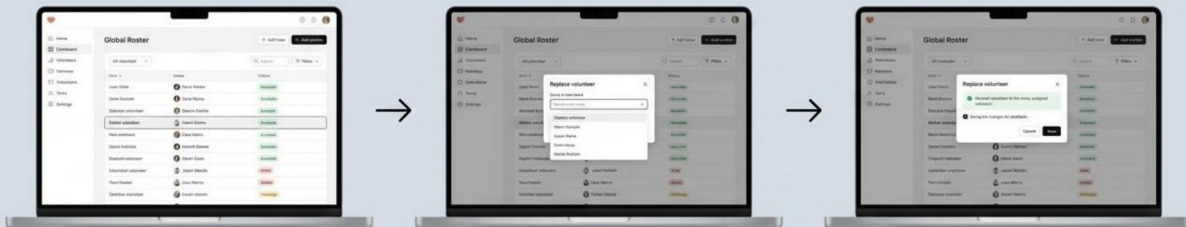
- **Household Pairing:** Parents and teenagers can be assigned to the same service dates, consolidating travel into a single car trip and simplifying family logistics.
- **Preferred Buddies:** Volunteers who prefer to work alongside a specific partner are paired together to increase retention and comfort.
- **Warm Replacements:** If a volunteer declines an assignment, the SMS replacement chain targets their preferred buddy or a household member first before contacting the broader candidate list.



NotebookLM

Manual interventions handle unexpected changes outside the automated loop

When a volunteer bypasses the system (e.g., phones the coordinator directly to cancel and nominates their own substitute), manual overrides are required.



1. Select

Selecting the specific roster slot in the Global Roster or Volunteer Details view.

2. Replace

Opening the 'Replace volunteer' dropdown modal to choose a specific substitute.

3. Save

Saving the changes. The new volunteer is instantly notified.

Alternative path: Select 'Save as Declined'. This marks the slot empty and intentionally hands the notification volunteer now and intentionally lands control back to the automated SMS chain to find a backup autonomously.

NotebookLM

Best Practices for Empathetic Rostering

Master the system by adhering to these four foundational rules:



1. Sync First

Always pull fresh Infoodle data and execute Step 0 upon making season changes before commanding a build.



2. Give Notice

Respect people's planning horizons by dispatching availability requests two to three weeks prior to a new season.



3. Review Before Sending

Never dispatch notifications blindly. Always audit the Global Roster for "Red" unfilled slots.



4. Trust the Chain

Resist the urge to micromanage cancellations. Allow the automated SMS system to handle sick calls and locate replacements autonomously.

Empower your volunteers. Simplify your scheduling.

NotebookLM

Fair, automatic, kind rostering for churches and volunteer organisations.

What is Rostas?

Rostas is your organisation's volunteer roster assistant. It handles the time-consuming, people-sensitive work of building rosters, collecting availability, and finding replacements when someone can't make it — automatically, fairly, and kindly.

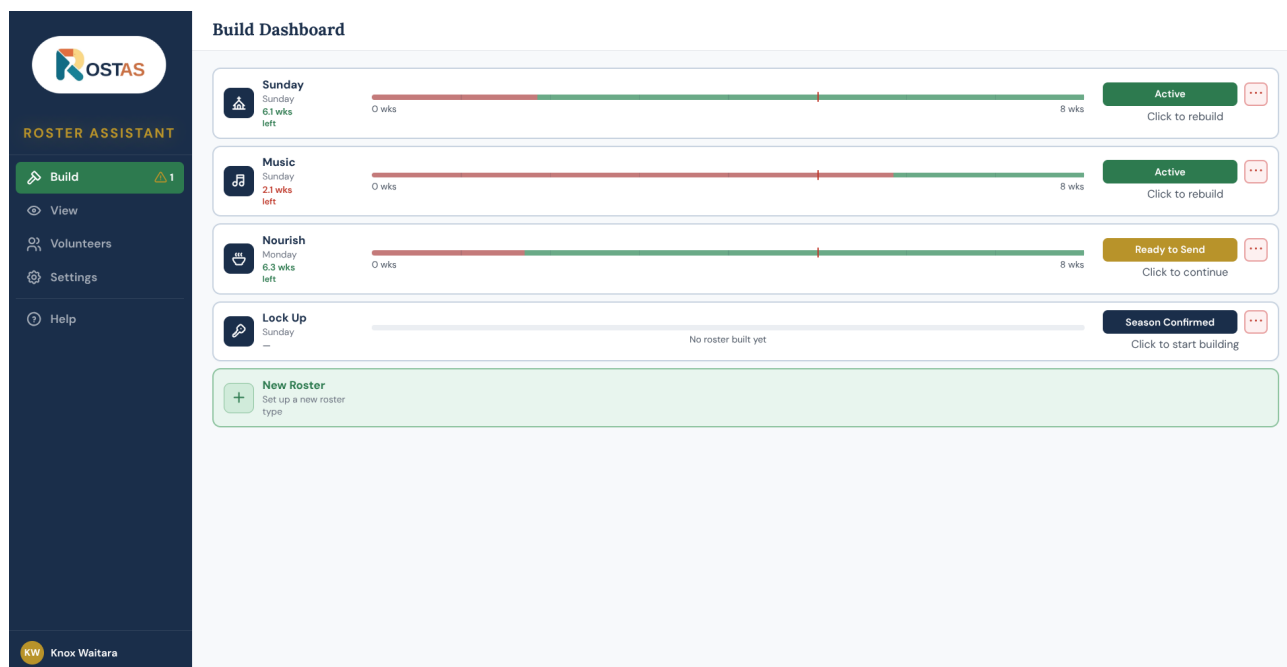
Once set up, Rostas runs most of the roster cycle on its own. Your job shifts from juggling spreadsheets and chasing people by text to simply reviewing what Rostas has prepared and pressing go.

How Rostas Works — The Big Picture

Rostas works in a rhythm that repeats every few weeks. The six-step Run Sheet Wizard guides you through each stage in order:



The six-step roster lifecycle. The Run Sheet Wizard guides you through each step — each stage is triggered by a single button.



The Build Dashboard — your starting point for each roster cycle. Each card shows the current build status for that roster type.

Key Concepts

Availability — Simple for Volunteers

Before each build, Rostas emails your volunteers asking which upcoming dates they're available. Volunteers receive a personalised link — no password, no app — and see a simple calendar of dates. Everything starts as **Available** — volunteers only change the dates they can't make.

The Intelligent Matching Engine

Time (Availability)

Volunteers dictate when they serve.

A diagram illustrating the matching engine. On the left, a box titled 'Time (Availability)' contains three buttons: 'Available' (green), 'Unsure' (yellow), and 'Can't make it' (red). A green arrow points from the 'Available' button to a central padlock icon. On the right, a box titled 'Talent (Preference)' contains text about a 4-tier priority system and a list of preferences. A blue arrow points from the 'Talent (Preference)' box to the same central padlock icon. Below the padlock, text reads 'Automatically slotting the perfect person into the roster.' The background is light blue with faint geometric shapes.

Available

Unsure

Can't make it

Talent (Preference)

The 4-tier priority system respects what volunteers actually want to do:
**Yes, I do this, Happy to fill in,
Not for me, or Skip.**

A screenshot of a mobile app interface. At the top, it shows the time '9:41' and signal/battery icons. Below is a section titled 'Role preference' with a sub-section 'Door & Offering'. Under 'Door & Offering', there is a green checkmark icon followed by the text 'Yes, I do this'.

9:41

Role preference

Door & Offering

✓ Yes, I do this

Automatically slotting the
perfect person into the roster.

NotebookLM

Volunteers tap their dates on a simple form. Everything defaults to Available — they only mark the dates they can't make.

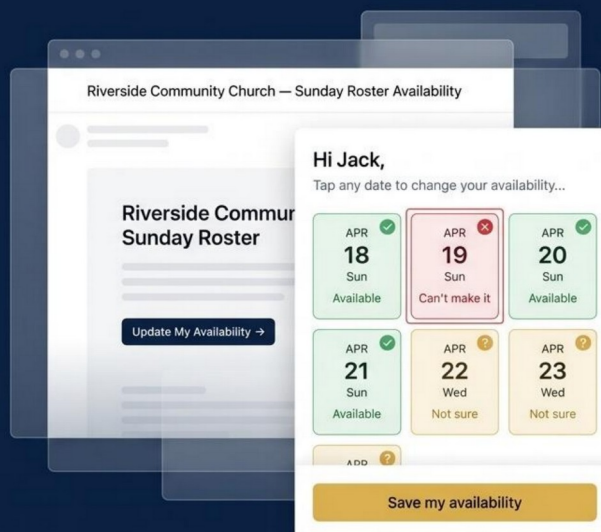
If a volunteer doesn't respond, Rostas sends an automatic SMS nudge after a configurable number of days. No manual chasing needed.

The roster engine doesn't fill slots blindly. It uses a four-tier priority system that respects both when volunteers can serve and what they actually want to do:

Frictionless Volunteer Experience

Volunteers receive a personalised link. Everything defaults to **Available**—they **only need to tap the dates** they cannot make.

- 🕒 If they forget to respond within a few days, Rostas automatically sends a configurable SMS nudge, saving the coordinator from manual follow-ups.



The engine combines availability (when volunteers can serve) with role preferences (what they want to do) to find the best person for every slot.

Within each tier, Rostas selects the volunteer who has been rostered least recently — keeping things fair automatically over time without any manual tracking.

The Roster Board

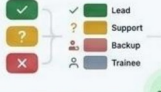
The Board is your day-to-day view of the current roster. It shows every slot, every date, and every volunteer assignment at a glance. A traffic light colour system tells you instantly what's filled, what's pending, and what needs attention.

The Roster Board — every slot colour-coded so you can see at a glance what's filled, pending, and needs attention.

The Automated SMS Replacement Chain

When a rostered volunteer can't make it, they tap a link in their notification email. Rostas immediately starts working through the backup list — no coordinator involvement needed.

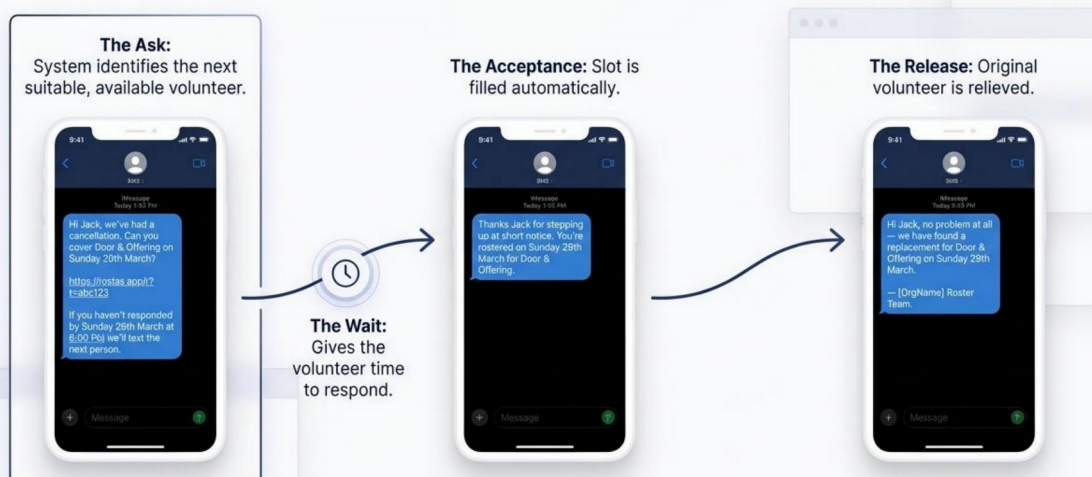
A Paradigm Shift in Coordination

	The Manual System	The Rostas Way
Time Spent	2–3 hours of individual chasing.	<1 hour via a guided, button-triggered wizard. 
Availability	Flattened 'Yes/No' guesswork.	Nuanced 3-state availability + 4-tier role preferences. 
Cancellations	Coordinator manually calls around in a panic.	Automated SMS replacement sequence (respecting configurable quiet hours). 
Retention	High risk of volunteer burnout.	Automated frequency caps and self-serve opt-outs. 

NotebookLM

Every notification includes a "Can't make it?" link. When tapped, the automated replacement engine starts — the coordinator's phone doesn't ring.

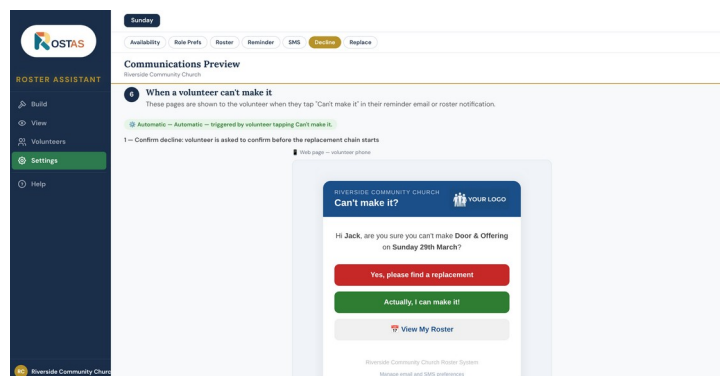
The Automated SMS Cascade



Quiet Hours Respected. SMS messages are blocked by default between 9:00 PM and 8:00 AM, holding messages in a queue so nobody is disturbed at night. 

The SMS replacement chain: Rostas texts the next suitable volunteer, waits for a reply, and keeps going until the slot is filled. The original volunteer is automatically released once a replacement accepts.

Quiet hours are always respected. Rostas never sends automated SMS between 9pm and 8am. If the replacement chain is running overnight, it pauses and resumes in the morning automatically.



What a "Can't Make It" request looks like on a volunteer's phone — a clear message with a link to proceed or change mind and continue being rostered on that day.

Looking After Your Volunteers

Rostas is designed with your volunteers in mind, not just your roster.

Who Does What

Rostas is designed so that most of the routine work happens automatically. Here's how responsibilities divide between you, your volunteers, and Rostas:

Rostas doesn't replace your judgement. There will be times when you want to override what Rostas has built — swap two people, add someone manually, or put a slot on hold. The Board makes all of this easy. Rostas handles the routine so you can focus on the exceptions.

Where to Start

The guide is organised into six parts. Jump to the section that matches where you are right now:

When you open Rostas for the first time, the setup wizard runs automatically. It takes about five minutes and covers the essentials — your organisation name, your contact details, and a quick SMS test to make sure everything is working before your first roster build.

The wizard runs once. After it's complete, Rostas opens directly to the Build Dashboard on every future visit.

Before you start: Your Rostas coordinator needs to have set up the system and given you the link to open it. If you don't have a link yet, ask them for it.

The Setup Wizard

The wizard has four steps shown across the top of the screen. You can see at a glance how far through you are and what's coming next.

Step 1 — Your Organisation

The first step establishes your organisation's identity. The name you enter here appears in every message sent to volunteers — availability emails, roster notifications, and SMS reminders.

ROSTAS

Organisation
Riverside Com...

Your Details
Sarah

SMS
+6421000001

Done

ROSTAS

Your Organisation
This name appears in every message sent to volunteers.

Organisation name *
Riverside Community Church 26 / 40

Timezone *
New Zealand

Country / calling code *
+64 — New Zealand

Website (optional)
https://riversidechurch.org.nz

Next ->

Step 1 — enter your organisation name, timezone, and country code. The name appears in every volunteer-facing message Rostas sends.

Click **Next** → when all required fields are filled. The button stays disabled until everything is valid.

Step 2 — Your Details

Step 2 captures the primary coordinator's contact details. These are used for SMS test sends, coordinator escalation alerts when the replacement chain is exhausted, and the top bar of the coordinator app.

Step 2 — enter your name, email address, and mobile number. Your mobile must include the country code.

Include your country code in the mobile number. Enter it as +6421123456, not 021123456. Without the country code SMS delivery will fail.

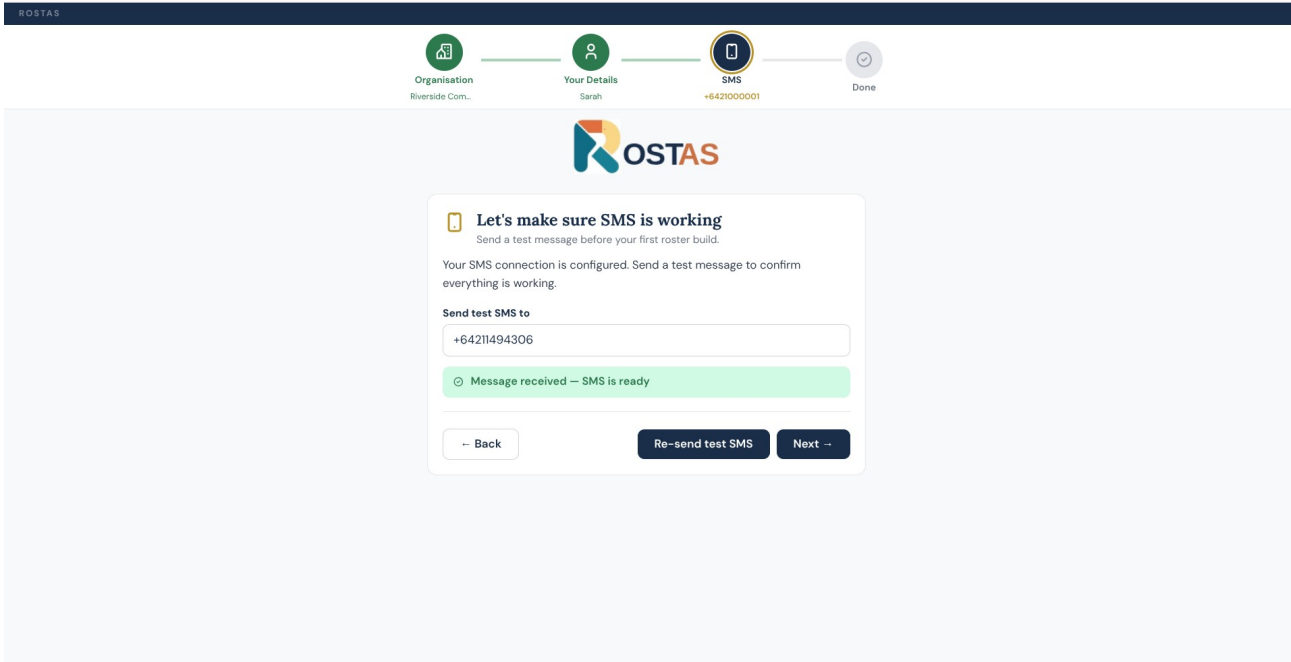
Step 3 — SMS Test

Before your first roster build, Rostas verifies that SMS is working. This step sends a real test message to your mobile so you can confirm everything is set up correctly.

Step 3 — your mobile number is pre-filled from Step 2. Tap "Send test SMS" to send a real test message to your phone.

How to complete Step 3

Your mobile number is pre-filled from Step 2. Tap **Send test SMS** → and wait for the message to arrive on your phone — usually within 30 seconds. Once received, a green confirmation appears and the Next button enables.

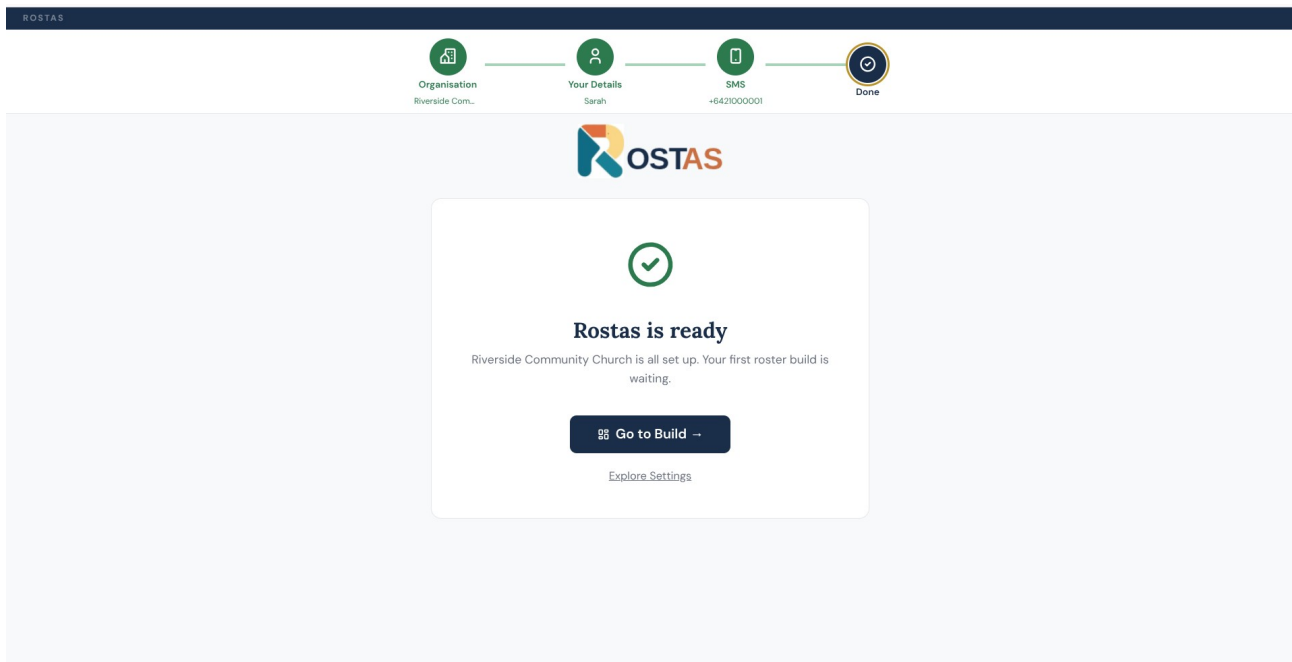


When the test message arrives, a green "Message received — SMS is ready" confirmation appears. Tap Next to continue.

If the test message doesn't arrive within a minute, check that your mobile number includes the country code and is entered correctly. You can edit the number in the field and try again. If it still fails, contact your tech support person — the SMS connection may need to be configured.

Step 4 — Done

Once SMS is confirmed, the wizard completes and Rostas is ready to use.



"Rostas is ready" — setup is complete. Click "Go to Build" to open the Build Dashboard and start your first roster cycle.

From here you have two options:

- **Go to Build →** — takes you straight to the Build Dashboard, ready to start your first roster cycle. This is the right choice if your volunteers are already imported.
- **Explore Settings** — opens the Settings view if you want to review or customise anything before your first build.

Adding Your Volunteers

Before you can build a roster, Rostas needs to know who your volunteers are. There are two ways to get them in:

Importing from CSV

If you have a spreadsheet of volunteers — from a previous roster system, a church database, or even a simple contact list — you can import them directly using the CSV Import Wizard. The wizard maps your spreadsheet columns to the right fields in Rostas and handles phone number formatting automatically.

To import volunteers from a spreadsheet

Go to **Volunteers** in the sidebar, then click **Import CSV**. The wizard walks you through uploading your file, mapping columns, and reviewing the results before importing. Phone numbers are automatically normalised to the correct international format for SMS delivery.

Your CSV needs at minimum: volunteer name and mobile number. Email address is strongly recommended so volunteers can receive roster notifications by email. Any additional columns can be mapped or skipped during the import.

Adding Volunteers Manually

To add a single volunteer, go to **Volunteers** in the sidebar and click **Add Volunteer**. Fill in their name, mobile, and email, then save. They'll appear in the volunteers list immediately and can be included in your next roster build.

What's Next

Once your volunteers are in, you're ready to build your first roster. Head to **Part C — The Roster Cycle** which walks you through the six-step wizard from start to finish.

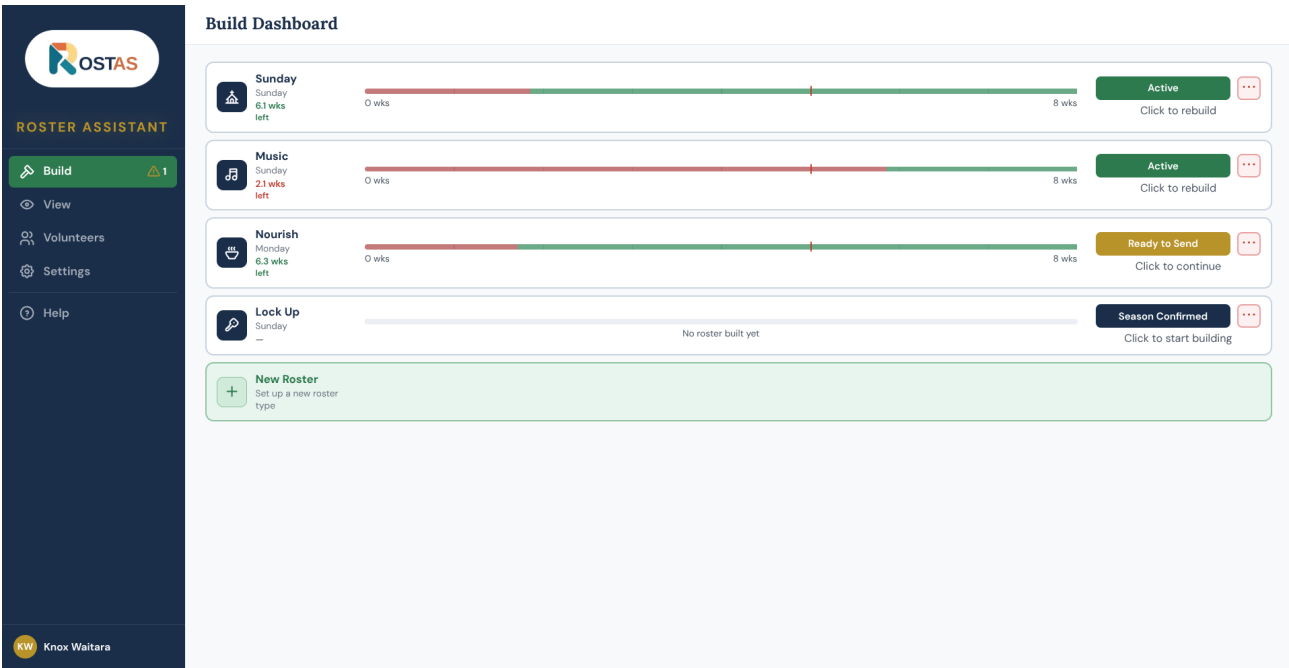
- ✓ Organisation name set
- ✓ Coordinator contact details set
- ✓ SMS test confirmed working
- ✓ Volunteers imported or added
- ○ Volunteer role preferences set (can be done during the wizard)

There are two roster wizards in Rostas. The **New Roster Wizard** runs once when you set up a new roster type — it defines the name, roles, season dates, and volunteers. The **Rebuild Wizard** runs every few weeks to collect availability, build the roster, and send notifications to volunteers.

Both start from the **Build Dashboard**.

The Build Dashboard

The Build Dashboard is your home base for all roster activity. It shows every active roster type with its current status and coverage bar at a glance.



The Build Dashboard — each card shows a roster type, its coverage bar, and current status. Click any card to open the wizard for that roster.

New Roster — the green card at the bottom of the dashboard. Click it to set up a brand new roster type from scratch.

The New Roster Wizard

Run this wizard when you're setting up a roster type for the first time — for example, adding a Music roster or a Hospitality team. It takes about 10 minutes and walks you through five steps: Name & Icon, Roles, Season, Volunteers, and Review.

You only run the New Roster Wizard once per roster type. After setup is complete, all future roster builds use the Rebuild Wizard instead.

Step 1 — Name & Icon

Give your roster a short name and choose an icon. The name appears in SMS messages, emails, and the coordinator app — keep it brief and clear.

New Roster Step 1 of 5

NAME & ICON ROLES SEASON VOLUNTEERS REVIEW

Name your roster

Give your new roster a short name. It will appear in tables, SMS messages, and emails.

Music

5 / 20

Next: Choose an icon --

RC Riverside Community Church

Step 1 — name your roster. This name appears in all volunteer communications, so keep it short and recognisable — e.g. "Sunday", "Music", "Hospitality".

After naming the roster, choose an icon that represents it. The icon appears on the Build Dashboard card and in the coordinator app sidebar.

Step 2 — Roles

Define the roles that need to be filled each time this roster runs. For each role, set a minimum and maximum number of people required.

Step 2 — add the roles for this roster. Set minimum and maximum people for each role. The engine will always try to fill the minimum; it won't exceed the maximum.

Role names matter. Use clear, specific names that volunteers will recognise — e.g. "Sound Desk", "Welcome Team", "Data Projection". These names appear in SMS messages and emails sent to volunteers.

Step 3 — Season

A season defines the date range, frequency, and day of week for this roster. Rostas uses seasons to calculate which dates to roster for, and to overlay public and school holidays automatically.

The screenshot shows the 'Season setup for Music' interface. On the left is a dark sidebar with the ROSTAS logo and navigation links: ROSTER ASSISTANT, Build (highlighted), View, Volunteers, Settings, and Help. The main content area is titled 'Season setup for Music' with the instruction 'Set the day, frequency, and date range, then preview the dates.' It includes sections for DAY OF WEEK (Sunday selected), FREQUENCY (Weekly selected), SEASON DATE RANGE (START: 14/06/2026, END: 26/09/2026, with a 'Preview dates' button), and HOLIDAY PAUSES (two unchecked checkboxes for school and public holidays). A 'PROJECTED DATES' section shows a calendar grid with dates from 14/06/2026 to 02/08/2026, highlighting school holidays on 05/07/2026 and 12/07/2026. At the bottom are 'Back' and 'Next: Add Volunteers' buttons. On the right, two informational boxes explain 'WHAT IS A SEASON?' and 'HOLIDAY PAUSES'.

Step 3 — set up your first season. Enter start and end dates, choose how often the roster runs (weekly or fortnightly), and select the day of week.

This screenshot shows the same 'Season setup for Music' interface but with a progress bar at the top. The progress bar has five steps: MUSIC, ROLES, SEASON (current step), VOLUNTEERS, and REVIEW. The 'Season setup for Music' form is identical to the previous screenshot, showing the same settings and projected dates. The 'Back' and 'Next: Add Volunteers' buttons are also present.

Once you've entered the season details, a preview of the roster dates appears — showing which dates fall within the season, with any public holidays already marked.

Step 4 — Volunteers

Select which volunteers from your list will serve on this roster. Only volunteers already in Rostas can be added here — if someone is missing, add them in the Volunteers section first then return to this step.

Screenshot coming — this section will be updated with a screenshot of the volunteer selection step shortly.

Step 5 — Review

The final step shows a summary of everything you've set up — roster name, roles, season dates, and volunteer count. Review it carefully before confirming.

New Roster Step 5 of 5

ROSTER ASSISTANT

- Build
- View
- Volunteers
- Settings
- Help

RC Riverside Community Church

MUSIC ROLES SEASON VOLUNTEERS REVIEW

Almost done!
Review everything below before creating your roster. Click any **Edit** link to go back and change a section — your other settings will be preserved. Once you click **Create Roster**, the roster will be active and ready to build.

Review: Music

ROSTER	Music	Edit
DAY	Sunday	Edit
FREQUENCY	Weekly	Edit
SEASON	Music_Build_1_Jun_2026 Sun Jun 14 2026 00:00:00 GMT+1200 (New Zealand Standard Time) – Sun Jul 26 2026 00:00:00 GMT+1200 (New Zealand Standard Time)	Edit
HOLIDAY PAUSES	None	Edit
ROLES	Vocals 1-2 Keyboard 1-1 Guitar 1-2 Drums 1-1	Edit
VOLUNTEERS	15 added	Edit

Back Create Roster

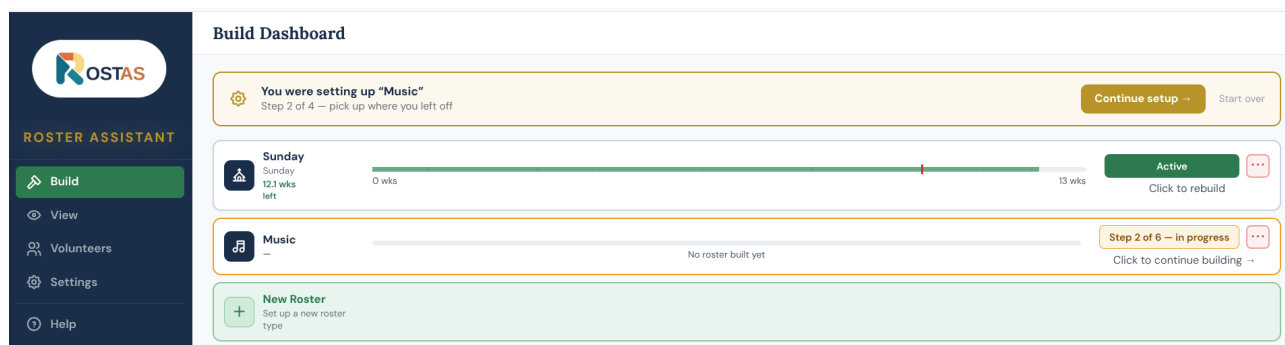
Step 5 — review your roster setup before confirming. You can go back to any previous step to make changes. Once confirmed, the roster appears on the Build Dashboard.

Click **Confirm & Create Roster** to finish. Your new roster type appears on the Build Dashboard immediately. You're now ready to run your first Rebuild Wizard for this roster.

The Rebuild Wizard

The Rebuild Wizard is the recurring roster cycle you run every few weeks. It collects availability from volunteers, builds the roster automatically, lets you review it, and sends notifications — all in six guided steps.

To start, click any roster card on the Build Dashboard. If a build is already in progress, you'll be taken straight to where you left off.



When a build is in progress, the dashboard shows where you left off. Click the card to resume from that step.

Step 1 — Refresh & Sync

The first step refreshes your seasons calendar — overlaying public and school holidays — and confirms your volunteer list is current. This takes about 30 seconds and happens automatically when you start.

Always run this step at the start of each new cycle. It ensures your dates are correct before availability emails go out.

Step 2 — Role Preferences

This step gives volunteers the opportunity to update their role preferences — which roles they're willing to perform. You can either send a role preference email to all volunteers, or skip this step if preferences are already up to date.

When to send role preference emails

Send them at the start of a new season, when new volunteers have joined, or when you know someone's availability for certain roles has changed. For a routine rebuild mid-season, it's usually safe to skip this step.

Step 3 — Availability

Rostas emails all active volunteers asking which upcoming dates they're available. Each volunteer receives a personalised link — no login required. They tap their dates, mark any they can't make, and save.

Allow 5-7 days for responses before moving to Step 4. Volunteers who don't respond within a configurable number of days automatically receive an SMS

Step 4 — Build Roster

With one click, the roster engine analyses every volunteer — their availability, role preferences, how recently they've served, and their monthly frequency cap — and fills every slot automatically. The build takes about 30 seconds for most rosters.

The engine uses a four-tier priority system — see Part A, The Intelligent Matching Engine for full detail on how slots are filled.

Step 5 — Check Roster

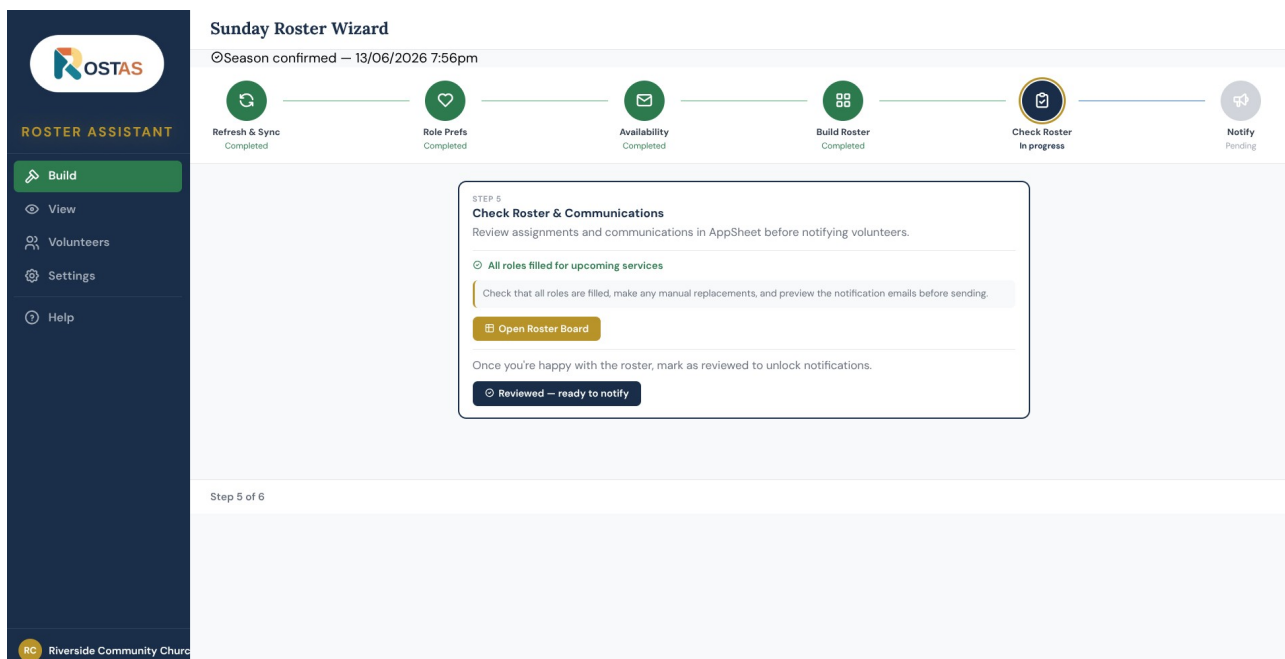
Before anything is sent to volunteers, you review what Rostas has built. Clicking **Check Roster** opens the Roster Board in a special review mode — you can see every assignment, make any manual changes needed, and then return to the wizard to send notifications.

Sunday Roster Board

Reviewing your newly built roster — make any changes, then return to the wizard to notify volunteers.

	Baking for Morning Tea		Barista Coffee		Door & Offering		Prayer Ministry		Serving Morning Tea	
Sun 19 Jul 2026 10/10	Emma Larsen Sun 19 Jul	Lisa Ngatai Sun 19 Jul	Amy Thornton Sun 19 Jul	Grace Kim Sun 19 Jul	Daniel Ferreira Sun 19 Jul	David Chen Sun 19 Jul	Sarah Mitchell Sun 19 Jul	Mark Sullivan Sun 19 Jul	Rachel Osei Sun 19 Jul	Chris Parata Sun 19 Jul
Sun 26 Jul 2026 10/10	Emma Larsen Sun 26 Jul	Lisa Ngatai Sun 26 Jul	Amy Thornton Sun 26 Jul	Grace Kim Sun 26 Jul	James Taufa Sun 26 Jul	Tom Bradshaw Sun 26 Jul	Fiona Walsh Sun 26 Jul	David Chen Sun 26 Jul	Priya Sharma Sun 26 Jul	Rachel Osei Sun 26 Jul
Sun 2 Aug 2026 10/10	Emma Larsen Sun 2 Aug	Lisa Ngatai Sun 2 Aug	Amy Thornton Sun 2 Aug	Ben Nakamura Sun 2 Aug	Daniel Ferreira Sun 2 Aug	James Taufa Sun 2 Aug	Sarah Mitchell Sun 2 Aug	Fiona Walsh Sun 2 Aug	Chris Parata Sun 2 Aug	Priya Sharma Sun 2 Aug
Sun 9 Aug 2026 10/10	Emma Larsen Sun 9 Aug	Lisa Ngatai Sun 9 Aug	Amy Thornton Sun 9 Aug	Ben Nakamura Sun 9 Aug	Tom Bradshaw Sun 9 Aug	James Taufa Sun 9 Aug	David Chen Sun 9 Aug	Sarah Mitchell Sun 9 Aug	Rachel Osei Sun 9 Aug	Chris Parata Sun 9 Aug
Sun 16 Aug 2026 10/10	Emma Larsen Sun 16 Aug	Lisa Ngatai Sun 16 Aug	Amy Thornton Sun 16 Aug	Grace Kim Sun 16 Aug	Daniel Ferreira Sun 16 Aug	Tom Bradshaw Sun 16 Aug	Mark Sullivan Sun 16 Aug	Sarah Mitchell Sun 16 Aug	Priya Sharma Sun 16 Aug	Rachel Osei Sun 16 Aug
Sun 23 Aug 2026 10/10	Emma Larsen Sun 23 Aug	Lisa Ngatai Sun 23 Aug	Amy Thornton Sun 23 Aug	Ben Nakamura Sun 23 Aug	James Taufa Sun 23 Aug	Tom Bradshaw Sun 23 Aug	Fiona Walsh Sun 23 Aug	Mark Sullivan Sun 23 Aug	Chris Parata Sun 23 Aug	Priya Sharma Sun 23 Aug
Sun 30 Aug 2026 10/10	Emma Larsen Sun 30 Aug	Lisa Ngatai Sun 30 Aug	Amy Thornton Sun 30 Aug	Grace Kim Sun 30 Aug	Daniel Ferreira Sun 30 Aug	James Taufa Sun 30 Aug	David Chen Sun 30 Aug	Mark Sullivan Sun 30 Aug	Rachel Osei Sun 30 Aug	Chris Parata Sun 30 Aug
Sun 6 Sep 2026 10/10	Emma Larsen Sun 6 Sep	Lisa Ngatai Sun 6 Sep	Amy Thornton Sun 6 Sep	Ben Nakamura Sun 6 Sep	Tom Bradshaw Sun 6 Sep	Daniel Ferreira Sun 6 Sep	Fiona Walsh Sun 6 Sep	Sarah Mitchell Sun 6 Sep	Priya Sharma Sun 6 Sep	Rachel Osei Sun 6 Sep

The Roster Board opens in review mode with a gold "← Back to wizard" button at the top. Review all assignments, make any swaps needed, then click Back to wizard when you're ready to notify volunteers.

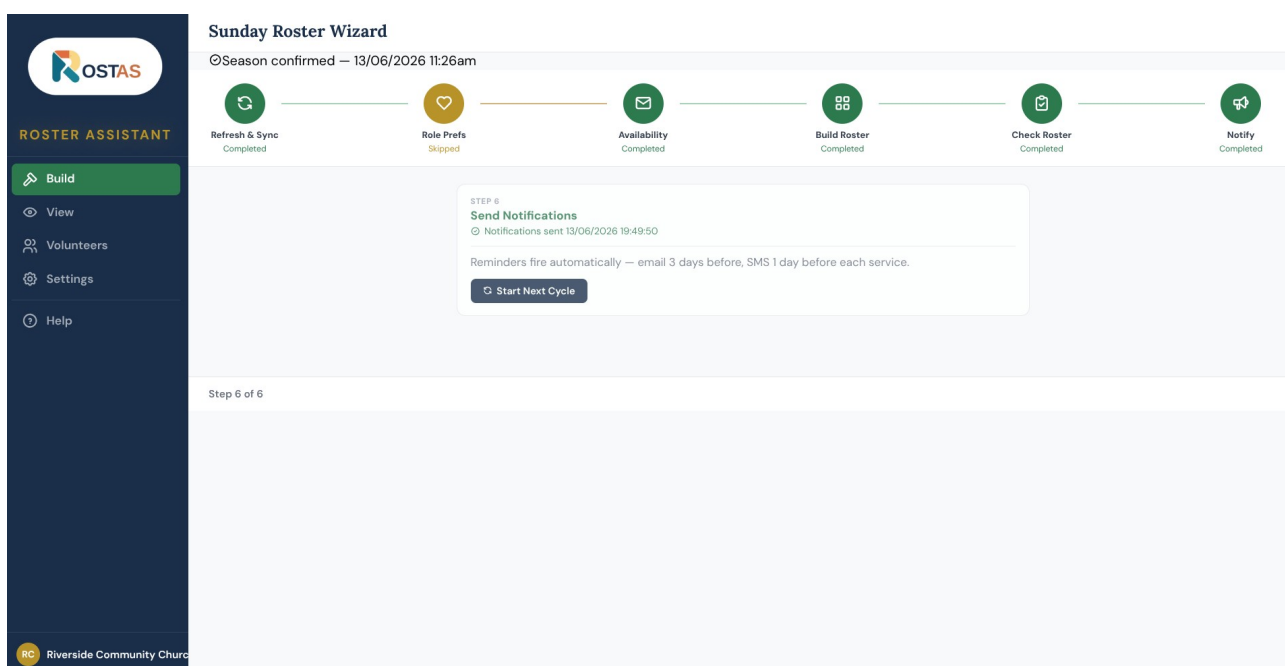


The Communications Preview tab shows exactly what each volunteer will receive — check the email wording, volunteer names, roles, and dates before sending.

Don't skip this step. It's your last chance to catch problems before volunteers are notified. Check for unfilled slots, confirm the message wording looks right, and make any manual swaps needed.

Step 6 — Notify

Once you're satisfied with the roster, click **Send Notifications**. Every rostered volunteer receives a personalised email with their assignments and a "Can't make it?" link. An SMS is sent at the same time.



Step 6 complete — all six steps show green ticks. Notifications have been sent and automatic reminders are queued. The cycle is done until next time.

- Email reminder sent 3 days before each service date
- SMS reminder sent 1 day before each service date
- If a volunteer taps "Can't make it" — the SMS replacement chain starts automatically

Confirming a New Season

When the current season is coming to an end, the Build Dashboard shows a **Season Confirm** button on the relevant roster card. You need to confirm the next season's dates before you can run a new build.

Sunday Roster Wizard

Confirm New Season
Review the projected dates, set the season name, then confirm to create the season.

SEASON NAME
Sunday_Build_2_Sep_2026

START DATE
19/07/2026

END DATE
06/09/2026

PROJECTED DATES

19/07/2026 × 26/07/2026 × 02/08/2026 × 09/08/2026 × 16/08/2026 × 23/08/2026 × 30/08/2026 × 06/09/2026 × 13/09/2026 + 20/09/2026 +

dd/mm/yyyy e.g. Xmas Party + Add

Confirm Season

Refresh & Sync In progress

Role Prefs Up next

Availability Pending

Build Roster Pending

Check Roster Pending

Notify Pending

STEP 3: Role Preferences
Let Sunday volunteers nominate their Primary and Fillable roles.

Send emails so volunteers can set their own role preferences, or skip if the coordinator will set them directly in AppSheet.

Send Role Preference Emails Coordinator will set if required

The Season Confirm screen — review the proposed dates for the next season, adjust any that need changing, and confirm. Rostas automatically pauses dates that fall on public or school holidays based on your roster settings.

To confirm a new season

Click the **Season Confirm** button on the Build Dashboard card. Review the proposed start and end dates, adjust if needed, then click **Confirm Season**. The roster card updates and you can proceed with a new build.

Confirm the season early — ideally a few weeks before the current season ends, so you have time to collect availability and build the next roster before the first date arrives.

The Roster Board is where you manage the roster between builds. You'll come here to check on replacement progress, make manual swaps, confirm pending assignments, or search for a specific volunteer. Access it by clicking **View** in the sidebar.

Reading the Board

The Board shows every roster date as a row, with roles as columns. Each cell shows the assigned volunteer's name and date. Colour coding tells you the status of each assignment at a glance.

OSTAS

Sunday Roster Board

ROSTERED TOGETHER (Green icon)
NOT ROSTERED TOGETHER (Red icon)

Search volunteer...

ROSTER ASSISTANT

Tom Bradshaw Door & Offering 09/08/2026 Filled

Save as filled Save as declined Replace Close

	Baking for Morning Tea		Barista Coffee		Door & Offering		Prayer Ministry		Serving Morning Tea	
Sun 19 Jul 2026 10/0	Emma Larsen Sun 19 Jul	Lisa Ngatai Sun 19 Jul	Amy Thornton Sun 19 Jul	Grace Kim Sun 19 Jul	Daniel Ferreira Sun 19 Jul	David Chen Sun 19 Jul	Sarah Mitchell Sun 19 Jul	Mark Sullivan Sun 19 Jul	Rachel Osei Sun 19 Jul	Chris Parata Sun 19 Jul
Sun 26 Jul 2026 10/0	Emma Larsen Sun 26 Jul	Lisa Ngatai Sun 26 Jul	Amy Thornton Sun 26 Jul	Grace Kim Sun 26 Jul	James Taufa Sun 26 Jul	Tom Bradshaw Sun 26 Jul	Fiona Walsh Sun 26 Jul	David Chen Sun 26 Jul	Priya Sharma Sun 26 Jul	Rachel Osei Sun 26 Jul
Sun 2 Aug 2026 10/0	Emma Larsen Sun 2 Aug	Lisa Ngatai Sun 2 Aug	Amy Thornton Sun 2 Aug	Ben Nakamura Sun 2 Aug	Daniel Ferreira Sun 2 Aug	James Taufa Sun 2 Aug	Sarah Mitchell Sun 2 Aug	Fiona Walsh Sun 2 Aug	Chris Parata Sun 2 Aug	Priya Sharma Sun 2 Aug
Sun 9 Aug 2026 10/0	Emma Larsen Sun 9 Aug	Lisa Ngatai Sun 9 Aug	Amy Thornton Sun 9 Aug	Ben Nakamura Sun 9 Aug	Tom Bradshaw Sun 9 Aug	James Taufa Sun 9 Aug	David Chen Sun 9 Aug	Sarah Mitchell Sun 9 Aug	Rachel Osei Sun 9 Aug	Chris Parata Sun 9 Aug
Sun 16 Aug 2026 10/0	Emma Larsen Sun 16 Aug	Lisa Ngatai Sun 16 Aug	Amy Thornton Sun 16 Aug	Grace Kim Sun 16 Aug	Daniel Ferreira Sun 16 Aug	Tom Bradshaw Sun 16 Aug	Mark Sullivan Sun 16 Aug	Sarah Mitchell Sun 16 Aug	Priya Sharma Sun 16 Aug	Rachel Osei Sun 16 Aug
Sun 23 Aug 2026 10/0	Emma Larsen Sun 23 Aug	Lisa Ngatai Sun 23 Aug	Amy Thornton Sun 23 Aug	Ben Nakamura Sun 23 Aug	James Taufa Sun 23 Aug	Tom Bradshaw Sun 23 Aug	Fiona Walsh Sun 23 Aug	Mark Sullivan Sun 23 Aug	Chris Parata Sun 23 Aug	Priya Sharma Sun 23 Aug
Sun 30 Aug 2026 10/0	Emma Larsen Sun 30 Aug	Lisa Ngatai Sun 30 Aug	Amy Thornton Sun 30 Aug	Grace Kim Sun 30 Aug	Daniel Ferreira Sun 30 Aug	James Taufa Sun 30 Aug	David Chen Sun 30 Aug	Mark Sullivan Sun 30 Aug	Rachel Osei Sun 30 Aug	Chris Parata Sun 30 Aug
Sun 6 Sep 2026 10/0	Emma Larsen Sun 6 Sep	Lisa Ngatai Sun 6 Sep	Amy Thornton Sun 6 Sep	Ben Nakamura Sun 6 Sep	Tom Bradshaw Sun 6 Sep	Daniel Ferreira Sun 6 Sep	Fiona Walsh Sun 6 Sep	Sarah Mitchell Sun 6 Sep	Priya Sharma Sun 6 Sep	Rachel Osei Sun 6 Sep

RC Riverside Community Church

The Roster Board — dates run down the left, roles across the top. Click any cell to select it and see the available actions. Use the roster type tabs at the top to switch between rosters.

Legend and Frequency

The legend at the top of the board shows the four cell states. To the right, the **volunteer search** lets you find a specific person and see all their assignments highlighted across the board. The **Frequency** indicator shows how many times the currently searched volunteer has been rostered in the current period.

Taking Action on a Cell

Click any cell on the board to select it. The selected cell gets a navy border and an action bar appears at the top of the board showing who is assigned, what role, and what date — with buttons for the available actions.

The screenshot shows the Roster Assistant interface for a Sunday Roster Board. The board is organized into columns for different roles: Baking for Morning Tea, Barista Coffee, Door & Offering, Prayer Ministry, and Serving Morning Tea. Rows represent different dates, including Sun 19 Jul, Sun 26 Jul, Sun 2 Aug, Sun 9 Aug, Sun 16 Aug, Sun 23 Aug, Sun 30 Aug, and Sun 6 Sep. Each cell in the grid shows the name of the assigned volunteer and the date. A cell for 'James Taufa' is selected, and an action bar appears at the top of the board with buttons for 'Save as filled', 'Save as declined', 'Replace', and 'Close'.

Clicking a cell opens the action bar. From here you can save the assignment as filled, mark it as declined (which starts the SMS replacement chain), manually replace the volunteer, or close the selection.

Manual Replacement

When you click **Replace**, a panel appears showing all available volunteers for that role and date, sorted by priority tier. Each volunteer shows their availability status and how recently they've been rostered.

The screenshot shows the Roster Assistant interface. At the top, there's a navigation bar with 'Sunday' and 'Music' tabs. Below it, the 'Sunday Roster Board' is displayed, showing a grid of roles and dates. A modal window titled 'Available replacements — Prayer Ministry - 19/07/2026' is open, showing a list of volunteers sorted by priority tier. The list includes Fiona Walsh (Available - 12 wk ago), Ben Nakamura (No response - not previously rostered), Chloe Tanaka (No response - not previously rostered), David Parata (No response - not previously rostered), Emma Johansson (No response - not previously rostered), Ethan Blackwood (No response - not previously rostered), Hannah Tane (No response - not previously rostered), and James Taufa (No response - not previously rostered). Each volunteer has a 'Select' button. The main roster board shows the current assignment of Sarah Mitchell for the Prayer Ministry role on 19/07/2026. The interface also includes a sidebar with 'Build', 'View', 'Volunteers', 'Settings', and 'Help' options.

The replacement panel — volunteers are listed by priority tier. Tier 1 shows available volunteers with the role as their primary. Click Select next to any volunteer to assign them immediately.

The tiers match the engine. Tier 1 volunteers are available and have this as a primary role — the ideal replacement. Lower tiers are less ideal but still valid options. Pick the best fit for the situation.

The replacement volunteer is notified automatically. Once you click Select, Rostas sends them an SMS and email with their assignment details. You don't need to contact them separately.

The SMS Replacement Chain

When a volunteer taps "Can't make it" in their notification email — or when you click **Save as declined** on the board — Rostas starts the automated SMS replacement chain. It works through available volunteers one at a time until someone accepts.

Quiet hours apply to the SMS chain. Messages are never sent between 9pm and 8am. If the chain is running overnight it pauses automatically and resumes in the morning. You can monitor progress on the board — cells in the SMS chain state show in blue.

Searching for a Volunteer

Use the search field at the top right of the board to find a specific volunteer. As you type, their assignments are highlighted across the entire board — making it easy to see all their upcoming dates at once. The frequency bar shows how many times they've been rostered in the current period relative to their cap.

Use volunteer search before making a manual replacement. Search for the volunteer you're thinking of replacing them with first — check they're not already heavily rostered that period before adding another date.

The Volunteers section is where you manage everyone who serves in your organisation. Access it by clicking **Volunteers** in the sidebar. From here you can view all volunteers, add new ones, edit details, and manage per-roster settings like role preferences, frequency caps, and availability.

The Volunteers List

The volunteers list shows every volunteer in the system — their name, roster types, phone number, and email at a glance. Use the search bar to find someone quickly, or filter by Active, Inactive, or All.

Volunteers Import CSV Add Volunteer Search by name, email or phone.

15 volunteers · 15 active All 15 Active 15 Inactive 0

NAME	ROSTER TYPES	PHONE	EMAIL
● Sarah Mitchell	Sunday	6421000001	sarah@riverside.example.com
● James Taufa	Sunday	6421000002	james@riverside.example.com
● Emma Larsen	Sunday	6421000003	emma@riverside.example.com
● David Chen	Sunday	6421000004	david@riverside.example.com
● Rachel Osei	Sunday	6421000005	rachel@riverside.example.com
● Tom Bradshaw	Sunday	6421000006	tom@riverside.example.com
● Lisa Ngatai	Sunday	6421000007	lisa@riverside.example.com
● Mark Sullivan	Sunday	6421000008	mark@riverside.example.com
● Grace Kim	Sunday	6421000009	grace@riverside.example.com
● Daniel Ferreira	Sunday	6421000010	daniel@riverside.example.com
● Amy Thornton	Sunday	6421000011	amy@riverside.example.com
● Chris Parata	Sunday	6421000012	chris@riverside.example.com
● Fiona Walsh	Sunday	6421000013	fiona@riverside.example.com

The Volunteers list — all volunteers in one place. Search by name, email, or phone. Click any row to open that volunteer's detail page.

Click any row to open the volunteer's full detail page — where you can edit their information, manage their roster preferences, set frequency caps, and view their availability history.

Adding a Volunteer

To add a new volunteer, click **Add Volunteer** in the top right of the Volunteers list. Fill in their details and save — they'll appear in the list immediately and can be included in your next roster build.

New volunteer details

FULL NAME *

MOBILE PHONE *

Local numbers are converted automatically e.g. 0211234567 → +64211234567

EMAIL

ROSTER TYPES *

☒ Sunday

Select at least one roster this volunteer will be part of

The Add Volunteer form — enter the volunteer's name, mobile number, email, and which roster types they serve in. Mobile must include the country code.

Mobile number format matters. Enter numbers in full international format including country code — e.g. +6421123456, not 021123456. Incorrectly formatted numbers will fail to receive SMS messages silently.

Importing Volunteers from CSV

If you have a spreadsheet of volunteers, use the CSV Import Wizard to bring them in all at once. Click **Import CSV** in the top right of the Volunteers list.

	A	B	C	D	E
1	Full_Name	Phone	Email	Ministry_Pref	
2	Sarah Mitchell	+6421345678	sarah.mitchell@email.com	Sunday	
3	James Taufa	+6421456789	james.taufa@email.com	Sunday	
4	Rebecca Chen	+6421567890	rebecca.chen@email.com	Sunday	Music
5	David Parata	+6421678901	david.parata@email.com	Music	
6	Emma Johansson	+6421789012	emma.johansson@email.com	Sunday	
7	Thomas Ngata	+6421890123	thomas.ngata@email.com	Sunday	Nourish
8	Olivia Patel	+6421901234	olivia.patel@email.com	Music	
9	Marcus Williams	+6421012345	marcus.williams@email.com	Sunday	
10	Hannah Tane	+6422123456	hannah.tane@email.com	Sunday	Music
11	Liam Fraser	+6422234567	liam.fraser@email.com	Nourish	
12	Sophie Anderson	+6422345678	sophie.anderson@email.com	Sunday	
13	Noah Pereira	+6422456789	noah.pereira@email.com	Sunday	
14	Grace Hohepa	+6422567890	grace.hohepa@email.com	Music	
15	Ethan Blackwood	+6422678901	ethan.blackwood@email.com	Sunday	Nourish
16	Chloe Tanaka	+6422789012	chloe.tanaka@email.com	Sunday	
17					

The CSV Import Wizard — map your spreadsheet columns to the right Rostas fields. Phone numbers are automatically normalised to international format during import.

How to import from CSV

Go to **Volunteers → Import CSV**. Upload your spreadsheet file, then map each column to the correct Rostas field (name, mobile, email, roster type). Review the preview, then click Import. Any phone numbers that are missing the country code are automatically corrected during import.

Your CSV needs at minimum: Full name and mobile number. Email is strongly recommended. If your spreadsheet has a column for roster type or ministry preference, map it during import and volunteers will be automatically assigned to the right rosters.

Volunteer Detail Page

Click any volunteer in the list to open their detail page. This is where you manage everything about that volunteer — their contact details, which rosters they're in, role preferences, frequency caps, availability, and notes.

The Volunteer Detail Page for Sarah Mitchell (SM) is shown. The left sidebar contains navigation links: Build, View, **Volunteers**, Settings, and Help. The main content area displays contact details for Sarah Mitchell (6421000001, sarah@riverside.example.com) and toggles for Active, Email, and SMS. It also shows roster types (Sunday selected), notes, and roster settings for Sunday. The roster settings include roles (Baking for Morning Tea, Barista Coffee, Door & Offering, Prayer Ministry, Serving Morning Tea), relational rostering (Buddy, Household), and next roster availability (SEP 13, 20, 27, OCT 4, 11, 18, 25, NOV 1, 8).

The Volunteer detail page — contact details and toggles on the left, roster-specific settings on the right. Use the roster type tabs to switch between rosters the volunteer serves in.

Contact Details and Toggles

The left panel shows the volunteer's name, phone, email, and active status. Three toggles control their participation:

Roster Settings

The right panel shows settings for the currently selected roster type. Use the roster type tabs at the top of the left panel to switch between rosters if the volunteer serves in more than one.

The right panel — roles, frequency cap, buddy/household settings, and availability tiles for the selected roster type. Scroll down to see all sections.

Adding a Volunteer to a New Roster

If a volunteer starts serving in an additional roster type, click the inactive roster tab on their detail page. A confirmation dialog appears — confirm to add them to that roster. Their settings for the new roster start fresh and can be configured from the right panel.

Clicking an inactive roster tab shows a confirmation before adding the volunteer. Once confirmed they appear in that roster's volunteer pool at the next build.

What Volunteers See

Volunteers interact with Rostas entirely through personalised links sent by email or SMS — no login, no app to download. There are three volunteer-facing pages:

Riverside Community Church

YOUR UPCOMING ROSTER



YOUR LOGO

Dear Jack,

Thank you for your willingness to serve at [OrgName]. Here are your upcoming roster assignments:

Sunday, 29 March 2026

☒ **You're Rostered On**

Door & Offering

☒ **Can't make it**

Sunday, 5 April 2026

☐ **Can you make it?**

Baking for Morning Tea

☒ **Yes, I can make it**

☒ **Can't make it**

Please plan to arrive a few minutes early so everything is ready before the service begins. If you have any questions, get in touch with **Sarah Mitchell** at coordinator@knoxwaitara.org.nz.



View My Roster

The volunteer roster view — shows upcoming assignments in a clean mobile-friendly layout. Volunteers access this via the link in their notification email.

All volunteer pages are mobile-optimised. Most volunteers will open them on their phone directly from an email or SMS. No app installation, no account creation — just a tap.

The Settings view is where you configure how Rostas behaves — your organisation's identity, SMS credentials, message wording, timing rules, and more. Open it by clicking **Settings** in the left sidebar.

The Settings View

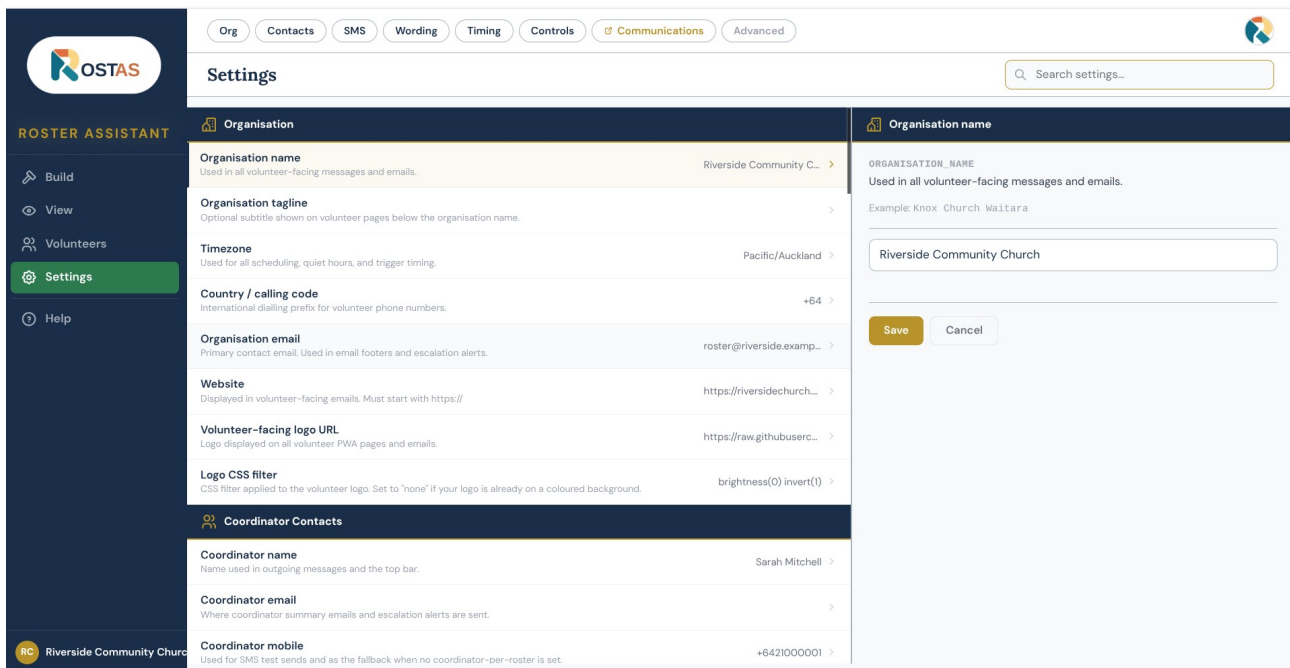
Finding your way around

The Settings view has two parts that work together.

The **chip strip** runs across the top and lets you jump directly to any category — Org, Contacts, SMS, Wording, Timing, Controls, System Status, and Advanced. Clicking a chip scrolls the left panel to that section instantly. The **Communications** chip (gold, with an arrow) opens the Communications Preview in place of Settings — use it to see how your message templates look before sending.

The **search bar** (top right, "Search settings...") filters the left panel live as you type. It searches across setting names and descriptions simultaneously — so typing "SMS" shows not just the SMS category but any setting whose description mentions SMS, across all categories. Non-matching rows disappear; categories with no matches collapse. Clear the search to restore the full list.

The chip strip across the top of Settings — click any category pill to jump straight to that section. The gold Communications chip opens the message preview.



The Settings view — categories and settings in the left panel, the selected setting's detail and edit field in the right panel.

The two-column layout

- **Left panel** — the scrollable list of all settings, grouped by category. Each row shows the setting name, a one-line description, and its current value on the right. Click any row to open it for editing.
- **Right panel** — appears when you click a row. Shows the full description, an example value, the input field, and Save/Cancel buttons. The panel stays fixed while you scroll the left panel, so you can read and compare other settings without losing your place.

To close the right panel without saving, click Cancel or click a different row.

Editing a setting

1. Click the row in the left panel. The right panel opens showing the setting name, description, and current value pre-filled in the input.
2. Make your change. The input type matches the setting — dropdowns for timezone and country code, toggles for on/off settings, text fields for everything else.
3. Validation runs as you type or on blur. If the value is invalid (wrong format, missing required content) the field turns red with an explanation. The Save button stays disabled until the value is valid.
4. Click **Save**. The left panel updates immediately to show the new value — no page reload needed.

Using System Status

The System Status card and the settings list below it are designed to work together. The card tells you what's wrong; the settings list is where you fix it.

Treat System Status as your starting point every time you open the Settings page. Before searching for a specific setting or making a planned change, glance at the Warnings column first. If it shows green — "All systems go" — you can proceed with whatever you came to do. If it shows amber or red, deal with those first, because some warnings mean volunteers aren't receiving messages right now.

The screenshot shows the ROSTAS Settings page. The top navigation bar includes tabs for Org, Contacts, SMS, Wording, Timing, Controls, Communications, System Status (selected), and Advanced. The left sidebar shows the ROSTER ASSISTANT menu with options: Build, View, Volunteers, Settings (selected), and Help. The main content area is titled 'Settings' and features a 'System Status' card. This card is divided into three columns: WARNINGS, ROSTER HEALTH, and COUNTS. The WARNINGS column shows three red indicators: 'SMS is disabled. Volunteers will not receive replacement requests or reminders.', 'SMS test mode is ON. All SMS are being redirected to the coordinator phone.', and 'Email test mode is ON. All emails are going to the coordinator only.' The ROSTER HEALTH column shows a list of system health checks with red indicators for 'Board cache last rebuilt', 'Seasons calendar last rebuilt', 'Public holidays last fetched', and 'Daily maintenance last run'. The COUNTS column shows 'Audit log entries' at 2231, 'Pending commands' at 0, and 'Active replacement chains' at 0. Below these columns are three charts: 'ACTIVITY (7 DAYS)' showing a flat line at zero, 'COMMUNICATIONS SENT (7 DAYS)' showing a flat line at zero, and 'REPLACEMENT OUTCOMES' showing 100% Accepted, 0% Declined, and 0% Timed out. The bottom section of the page is titled 'Organisation' and contains fields for 'Organisation name', 'Organisation tagline', 'Timezone', 'Country / calling code', and 'Organisation email'. The 'Organisation tagline' field is currently empty, and the 'Organisation email' field is 'newsletters@waitara.o...'. The 'Organisation tagline' field has a 'Save' button next to it.

The System Status card — shows a red indicator when SMS is disabled and an amber indicator when test mode is on. Check this card if messages aren't being sent.

Following a warning to its fix

Every warning in the System Status card maps directly to one or more settings in the list below. Rather than hunting through categories manually, use the search bar — the warning text itself usually contains the keyword you need:

The typical workflow is: see the warning → type the keyword into the search bar → click the matching row → fix it in the right panel → save. The whole thing takes under a minute once you know the pattern.

After making a change, check the card again

The System Status card doesn't update automatically when you save a setting — it loaded when you opened Settings and reflects that moment in time. After fixing a warning, click **Refresh** in the System Status card header to reload it and confirm the warning has cleared. This is especially important for the SMS disabled and test mode warnings, where it's easy to accidentally save the wrong value.

Understanding your roster's rhythm

Once warnings are clear, the lower sections of the card give you a different kind of visibility — not problems to fix, but patterns to understand.

- **Activity sparkline** — tells you whether Rostas is actually doing things day-to-day. A healthy system shows green bars most days. If you see a flat line of zero bars across the past week, it may mean the daily triggers have stopped running

— cross-check with Roster Health to see if the maintenance and calendar rebuild timestamps are recent.

- **Communications Sent chart** — shows whether emails and SMS are actually going out. If you sent availability emails three days ago but the chart shows zero emails on that date, something suppressed them — check whether email test mode was on at the time (Quick Controls → Email test mode).
- **Replacement Outcomes bar** — useful after your first few roster cycles. A high timeout rate (amber) often means your replacement timers are too short for how quickly your volunteers respond, or that quiet hours are eating into available sending time. You can adjust both under SMS → Replacement timer settings and SMS quiet hours.
- **Communication Failures table** — the most direct diagnostic tool. If a volunteer tells you they never received a replacement SMS, open Settings, refresh System Status, and scroll to this table. If you see an ERROR entry for `sendSMS_Twilio_` on the date in question, the message was attempted but failed — the error message will tell you why (wrong credentials, Twilio account issue, etc.). If you see nothing for that date at all, the message may have been suppressed before it even reached the sending step — check SMS enabled, test mode, and quiet hours for that time window.

The feedback loop in practice

Think of it as three layers working together:

- **System Status card** — shows you what the system did, and what's misconfigured
- **Settings left panel** — lets you find and understand the relevant setting
- **Settings right panel** — lets you read the full description, see the example, and make the change safely

A coordinator who builds this habit — open Settings, check System Status, fix any warnings, then do what you came to do — will catch problems before volunteers notice them rather than after.

Settings Categories

- **Organisation** — your organisation's name, tagline, timezone, country calling code, contact email, website, and volunteer-facing logo. The organisation name is the most important field: it appears in every SMS and email sent to volunteers as [OrgName]. Get this right first.
- **Coordinator Contacts** — your name, email, and mobile, plus per-roster coordinator contacts for Sunday, Music, Nourish, and any other roster types you've added. The per-roster contacts receive escalation alerts when a replacement chain is exhausted with no one found.
- **SMS** — the SMS kill switch, test mode toggle, quiet hours, replacement timers, and Twilio credentials. See SMS settings in detail below.
- **Message Wording** — every SMS template and email text block that Rostas sends to volunteers. SMS templates show a live character counter and required placeholder checker. See Message wording below.
- **Timing & Behaviour** — how many weeks ahead to build rosters, freeze weeks, availability form deadline, reminder timing, and public holiday region.
- **Quick Controls** — per-roster active toggles and email test mode. Useful for temporarily hiding a roster from the Build wizard without deleting it, or for switching email test mode on and off quickly.
- **Advanced** — settings that affect system internals (web app URL, roster type list, Infoodle credentials). These are locked by default. Click Unlock to edit in the right panel and read the warning carefully before changing anything here. Incorrect values can stop roster builds or break SMS links. Contact tech support if unsure.

SMS Settings in Detail

Three settings here are worth understanding before you go live.

SMS enabled — the master kill switch. When this is false, no SMS leaves Rostas at all — not replacements, not reminders, not test sends. The System Status card shows a red warning when this is off. Only disable it deliberately (e.g. during a migration or if your Twilio account lapses).

SMS test mode — when true, every SMS that would go to a volunteer is redirected to the coordinator mobile instead. The message is prefixed with [TEST - would go to candidate]. Use this while setting up or testing replacement chains. Turn it off before your first real roster cycle. The System Status card shows an amber warning when test mode is on.

Quiet hours — SMS quiet hours start and end are set as 24-hour values (e.g. 21 = 9pm, 8 = 8am). Rostas will not send any SMS outside this window, including replacement chain advances. If a replacement request hits quiet hours, it waits until the quiet period ends before texting the next candidate. The default is 9pm–8am.

Replacement timers — three escalation speeds:

- **Normal** (default 120 min) — used when the service is more than 24 hours away
- **Urgent** (default 30 min) — used when the service is within 24 hours
- **Panic** (default 10 min) — used when the service is within 2 hours

If volunteers are frequently timing out before responding, consider increasing the normal timer. If you're often scrambling at short notice, reducing the urgent or panic timers gets through the candidate list faster.

Message Wording

Every SMS template has three protections built in to prevent accidental breakage.

SMS template fields show a live character counter, required placeholder list, and a preview button. The Save button is disabled if the message exceeds 160 characters or is missing a required placeholder.

- **Character counter** — SMS messages over 160 characters are split into two by carriers and charged as two texts. The counter below the textarea turns amber at 140 characters and red at 161+. The Save button is disabled when the count is red.
- **Required placeholders** — each template has a set of placeholders that must be present for it to work correctly. For example, the replacement request SMS must include [Link] — without it, volunteers have no way to respond. Missing placeholders are shown in red below the textarea. Save is blocked until all required placeholders are present.
- **Preview SMS** — click this button to see the template rendered with realistic sample values substituted in ([Name] → Sarah, [Role] → Welcome Team, [Date] → today's date, [Link] → a sample short URL). This shows you exactly what a volunteer will read, at the correct character count. It does not send a real SMS.

All placeholder names use square brackets: [Name], [Role], [Date], [Link], [OrgName], [Deadline]. Never use curly braces — {name} will not be substituted.

Template Placeholders

SMS and email templates use placeholders in square brackets that Rostas replaces with real values when sending. Never remove a required placeholder — if a required one is missing, the Save button is blocked.

Quick Controls

Quick Controls contains the most commonly needed on/off switches. Check these if something isn't behaving as expected.

Always check test modes are OFF before sending a real roster. If SMS_TEST_MODE or EMAIL_TEST_MODE is True, volunteers will not receive any messages — only you will.

Advanced Settings

The Advanced section is collapsed by default and greyed out. It contains settings that the system needs to function but that coordinators rarely need to touch. Changing them incorrectly can cause roster builds to fail or SMS links to break.

To edit an advanced setting: click the row, read the amber warning in the right panel, then click **Unlock** to edit. The field becomes editable. Save as normal.

The screenshot shows the ROSTAS Settings interface. The left sidebar contains navigation links: Build, View, Volunteers, Settings (highlighted), and Help. The top navigation bar includes tabs for Org, Contacts, SMS, Wording, Timing, Controls, Communications, and Advanced. The main content area is titled 'Settings' and features a search bar. The 'Advanced' section is expanded, displaying a list of settings. The 'Web app URL' setting is highlighted, showing its current value as 'https://script.google.co...'. The right panel provides details for the selected setting, including a warning icon and the text 'ROSTER_ACTIVE_Nourish Show Nourish in the Run Sheet Wizard. Example: TRUE'. The 'Nourish roster active' setting is also visible, showing a toggle switch set to 'Off'.

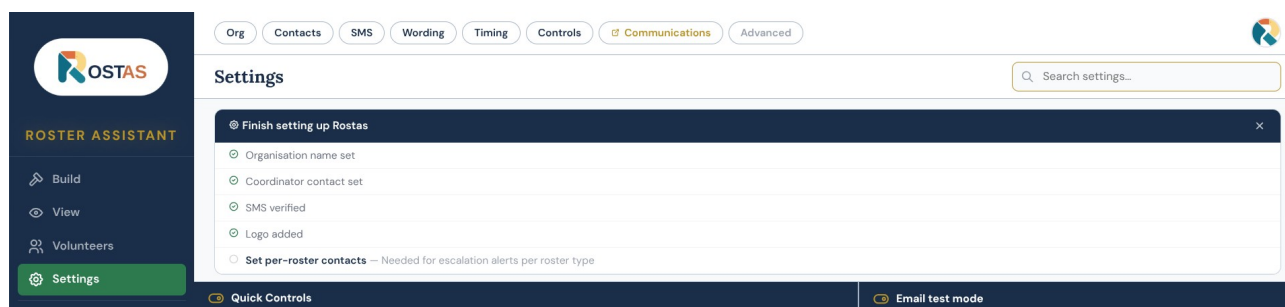
Advanced settings are collapsed by default and shown with a lock icon. Click "Unlock to edit" in the right panel to make changes — only do this if you're confident about what you're changing.

The most common reason a coordinator needs the Advanced section is after redeploying Rostas — the **Web app URL** must be updated to match the new deployment URL. If short links in SMS stop working after a redeployment, this is almost always the cause.

Advanced settings can break things if changed incorrectly. If you're unsure, leave them as they are or contact your tech support person before making changes.

Setup Checklist

After the initial setup wizard completes, a checklist card appears at the top of the Settings view. It shows which setup tasks are done and which still need attention. Click any incomplete item to jump straight to that setting.



The setup checklist — ticked items are confirmed complete, open circles need attention. Click any item to open the relevant setting. Dismiss the checklist once everything is done.

Troubleshooting

Most issues in Rostas fall into a small number of categories. Work through this list before contacting tech support.

Volunteers aren't receiving SMS messages

- Check **Settings** → **Quick Controls** → **SMS_ENABLED** is True
- Check **SMS_TEST_MODE** is False — if True, all messages go to the coordinator only
- Check the volunteer's SMS toggle is On in their detail page
- Check quiet hours — SMS won't send between 9pm and 8am
- Check the volunteer's mobile number is in correct international format (+64...)

Volunteers aren't receiving emails

- Check **EMAIL_TEST_MODE** is False in Quick Controls
- Check the volunteer's Email toggle is On in their detail page
- Ask the volunteer to check their spam/junk folder
- Confirm their email address is correct in their volunteer detail page

Roster has unfilled slots after building

- Check that enough volunteers have responded to the availability email
- Check that volunteers have role preferences set — without preferences set, the engine can't assign them
- Check frequency caps — volunteers who've hit their monthly cap won't be assigned further
- Consider rebuilding after more availability responses come in
- Use manual replacement on the Board to fill remaining slots

SMS replacement chain isn't progressing

- Check quiet hours — chain pauses between 9pm and 8am and resumes automatically
- Check **SMS_ENABLED** is True
- Check there are eligible volunteers left on the backup list — if the list is exhausted you'll receive an escalation SMS
- Use manual replacement on the Board to assign someone directly

When to contact tech support

Contact your tech support person if:

- SMS messages are failing with error messages in the system
- The web app URL has changed and volunteer links are broken
- You need to change Twilio or other API credentials
- Something is producing repeated errors that don't resolve on their own
- You need to add or remove a roster type
- Anything requiring access to the Google Apps Script editor

When contacting tech support, include a description of what you were doing, what you expected to happen, and what actually happened. A screenshot of any error message is very helpful.

